REBRANDING THE IDEA OF INDIA

From showcasing India's rich cultural heritage to reviving the pandemic-hit tourism sector and giving the Northeast a growth push, G. Kishan Reddy has had his hands full

By Kaushik Deka



TOURISM

IN 2020, THE INDIAN TOURISM SECTOR accounted for 39 million jobs, or 8 per cent of the total employment in the country. This was despite the devastating impact of Covid-19. The pandemic curtailed the movement of domestic tourists by nearly 70 per cent and foreign tourist arrivals fell by 91 per cent. In 2019, travel and tourism had contributed nearly 7 per cent to India's GDP. Foreign exchange earnings from 2016 to 2019 grew at a CAGR of 7 per cent. But Covid-19 brought the tourism and hospitality industry to a standstill. While the stimulus package to revive the Covid-hit economy covered tourism and hospitality, the tourism ministry also took several specific steps—from loan guarantee to formulating operational guidelines—to facilitate the revival of tourism. The ministry has also been continuing its flagship programmes to promote tourism. It provides financial assistance to state governments under the 'Swadesh Darshan', 'National Mission on Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual, Heritage Augmentation Drive (PRASHAD)', and 'Assistance to Central Agencies for Tourism Infrastructure Development' schemes. States also get funds for organising fairs and events under the Domestic Promotion and Publicity including Hospitality (DPPH) scheme. But as tourism is a state subject, real revival of the sector depends on the efficient execution of these schemes by the states. ■

WHAT'S DONE

- Implemented the Rs 250 cr Loan Guarantee Scheme for Covid Affected Tourism Service Sector for government-recognised tour operators, agents and transporters
- 500,000 free tourist visas announced after November 15, 2021 to attract foreign travellers to India
- Developed SAATHI (System for Assessment, Awareness & Training for Hospitality Industry) for Covid-safety in hotels, restaurants
- 76 infrastructure projects approved under Swadesh Darshan Scheme in 2021–22; 37 completed
- 800 seats created in government-run hospitality training and educational institutes in 2021–22

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Develop infrastructure at a faster pace with cooperation from states
- Provide greater financial assistance to smaller players in tourism, particularly in smaller cities
- Enact the new National Tourism Policy to help industry cope with the post-pandemic environment
- Produce more trained, multilingual professionals for the industry